intimidate the ships of other nations, from the Philippines and Vietnam to India, as they pass through waters where China contests the sovereignty of the Spratly and Paracel Island groups with a half dozen other Southeast Asian nations. It has militarized its possessions in those waters since the mid-2010s, and in doing so, it has shifted the balance of power in one of the world's most vital seas, through which passes nearly 70 percent of global trade, and which links the western Pacific to the Indian Ocean and routes to Europe. Beijing has turned once-submerged reefs into full island bases through a massive reclamation project, dredging up three thousand acres of reef bed to make islands and then outfitting them with airstrips, radar installations, weapons bunkers, and antiaircraft missile systems.[45] This militarization of Fiery Cross Reef, Mischief Reef, and Subi Reef, among others, was undertaken despite Chinese promises not to do so.[46]

Despite a weak American response during the Obama administration, which agonized over doing more frequent and publicized freedom of navigation operations, Chinese media darkly warned of war should Washington try to force Beijing to stop or reverse its island-building campaign. To smaller Southeast Asian nations, China's aggressive militarization of artificial islands represents a significant destabilization of the region's power equilibrium, yet almost all feel unable to do anything to materially counter Beijing's policy. This in turn raises questions about their sovereignty and the extent to which they (and the United States) can defend their interests. Learning to live with a newly assertive Chinese military is the major security challenge facing Asian nations in the twenty-first century.

A similar dynamic is taking place in both regional and global economies. Whereas China's rise has often created new trade and investment opportunities, the policies being put into place by Xi Jinping are raising analogous questions in Asia and beyond about economic sovereignty and the ability to resist China's swelling economic reach. Much of the concern focuses on Xi's bold bid to radically reshape trade and investment in Eurasia. He has pledged $1 trillion to his flagship One Belt One Road (OBOR) policy. The main focus of OBOR is